American border guards alike recognized and embraced him as "Ambassador Satch" on both sides of the wall.[14]

Not only did Berlin serve as a Cold War hot spot, but perspectives at or on the border related to the recent traumas of German history and lived on the layered cultural landscapes of the divided city. As a central site of Jewish trauma, the city, as a whole, emerged as a potential space for collective remembrance following the Holocaust. The center of a decimated Jewish Berlin, however, was located in the East. The division of Germany and its respective ruling powers thus informed processes of national reparation and memorialization that fit with their own ideological imperatives. For American Cold Warriors and their allies, the western side of the city embodied the transformations necessary to move the nation from fascism to democracy. Further, echoing the popular U.S. claim that equated Soviet totalitarianism with Nazi fascism, the Wall was both characteristic of Soviet desperation and reminiscent of Nazi-era repression.

The GDR, the border's eastern architects, however, neither saw nor spoke of the Berlin Wall in everyday parlance but instead referred to it only in official nomenclature as "an antifascist protective rampart." The Wall was kept purposefully out of proximate sight and reach, with grave consequences for encroachment.[15] The GDR's nefariously expansive regimes of "border control" not only kept its citizens from fleeing in droves, as they had failed to do through the period of nonenforced division of the city, but intended to ostensibly shield those kept there from a Western value system of "supercapitalism" and profit-driven economics that the GDR viewed as responsible for the rise of Nazism in the first place. By the 1970s, as the two Germanys settled into stabilized diplomatic relations, the border area remained volatile. In the fall of 1989, when a sweeping, peaceful revolution emerged led by German peace activists responding to loosening Soviet reforms across the Eastern bloc, they sang the borrowed African American civil rights hymn "We Shall Overcome" to call for dramatic political change but not necessarily the full dismantling of either the state or the Berlin Wall.[16] Such a cultural reverberation serves as a reminder that the simmering conflict at the Berlin Wall throughout its entire existence was tied to competing claims about the previous Nazi era of German history, as well as America's role as a catalyst and foil of freedom in Cold War Berlin.

The story of America's relationship and identification with the Berlin Wall has previously been told through decades of public history, popular